Winter Burrow

a mouse come home

You are a mouse come home from the city. Your parents are dead. The family burrow under the old beech has gone cold, and the aunt who kept it is gone. The snow is coming in.

Go out, bring things home, make the burrow warm again. Find out where she went.

Make a mouse

1. Roll 3d6 for STR, DEX and WIL in order, keeping the two highest each time. Swap two if you like.
2. Roll d6 for HP.
3. Roll d6 for your city trade and take both items.
4. Take a city coat (Warmth d8), a sharpened stick (d6), 2 Food and the letter.
5. Name yourself.

D6	CITY TRADE	ITEMS
1	**Seamstress**	Needle (d6, light: wears out slower than a stick). Thimble of buttons, good for trade
2	**Lamplighter**	Matches, 3 uses: a fire anywhere dry. Brass snuffer
3	**Porter**	Rope. Shoulder strap, +1 pack slot
4	**Baker**	Jar of honey, 3 Food. Copper pan: 1 Food cooks two full bellies, yours and a guest's
5	**Clerk**	Pencil and ledger: a route you've walked and written down costs 1 hour less, never below 1. Spectacles
6	**Factory hand**	Wrench (d6/d8), opens human things. Tin cup: hot drinks step Warmth up twice

Core rules

Saves. When the outcome is uncertain and failing costs something, roll d20 against STR, DEX or WIL. With advantage, roll two and take the lower. With disadvantage, take the higher.

D20 ROLL	RESULT
Equal to or under	You do it
Up to 5 over	You do it at a cost, or only partly. The GM says which
More than 5 over	It fails

When a rule names the failure (save or get wet, save or stuck), it's pass or fail.

Slots. You have 2 paw slots, 2 body slots and 6 pack slots. Every item, bundle and condition takes one. Food stacks 3 to a slot. Over the limit you are encumbered: disadvantage on everything and no running.

The day. Mark an hour for every hour of travel and every task. Places are joined by paths, and each path has its hours. Morning 4, Afternoon 4, Dusk 2, then Night.

No XP, no levels. The burrow is how you grow.

Fighting

Almost everything out there is bigger than you. Running and hiding are always on the table.

Who goes first. Strike before they know you're there and you go first. Otherwise, a DEX save to act before them. Keep that order.

Your turn. Move, and do one thing: attack, run, hide, talk, or try something risky like a trip or a feint. Then each of them acts.

Attacks always hit. Roll your weapon die, take off the target's Armour, and the rest comes off its HP. **Hampered** (in a web, grabbed, through cover): roll d4. **Set up** (a trick that worked, a target stuck or unaware): roll d12.

WEAPON	DAMAGE
Stick, needle, anything improvised	d6
Wrench, hatchet	d6, or d8 in both paws
Spear	d10, both paws
A weapon in each paw	Roll both, keep the best

Taking damage. It comes off HP, then STR. After any STR damage, a STR save: pass and you keep going, fail and you take Injured and go down. A bite "to DEX" works the same, but past HP it comes off DEX and the save is DEX. At DEX 0 you can't move. Your foes work the same way: one that fails its save flees or dies.

Running. From anything slower or busy, you're away. From anything faster, a DEX save, or it gets one more attack first.
Hiding. Get into cover. If it's looking, a DEX save.

After a fight, roll Warmth, because the sweat freezes. Roll d6 per weapon used: on 4–6, mark a use. A stick marks one every fight. Three uses and it breaks. A new stick: an hour at home and 1 Wood.

Healing. HP comes back with sleep. Lost STR, DEX and WIL come back one point each per night at home.

Going down. You don't die in Winter Burrow. The scene ends and the GM moves time on. You wake at the next Morning somewhere worse, with 1 HP, Warmth d4 and Injured. Clear all but one Chilled. Your bundles are lost in the snow. If STR hit 0, you wake at STR 1, Frostbitten too.

Warmth

Warmth is one die: d4, d6, d8, d10 or d12. Your clothes set your top die. You leave home at your top.

Roll Warmth every hour you mark outdoors, twice an hour at Night. On a 1 or 2, step it down one size. Getting wet counts as rolling a 1.

At d4, a step down puts a Chilled in a pack slot instead, and the die stays at d4.

Warming up

- A hot drink steps it up one, never above your top. Brew one at the hearth for 1 Food. It takes a slot and stays hot until Dusk.
- Shelter out of the wind means no roll that hour.
- A fire puts you back at your top. Each hour beside it clears one Chilled, and a night beside it clears them all.
- A fire away from home costs 1 Wood and needs somewhere dry.

CLOTHING	EFFECT
City coat	Top die d8
Scarf	Top die one step up
Mittens	Top die one step up
Felted boots	Deep snow costs no extra hour
Waxed cloak	Getting wet is no longer a 1

The Burrow

The burrow is a sheet of rooms, on the back of your character sheet. Every room starts Forlorn, more an idea than a room. Pay a rung's cost on a Mend to climb it. A room's first climb turns something up.

Hearth

Come home, light the fire, then do one thing before you sleep. No fire, you sleep Chilled.

Cook. Spend 1 Food, your day's Food, for a full belly.

Mend. Restore a room.

Make. Make a tool at the workbench.

Knit. Knit a garment. A scarf can be knitted anywhere.

Remember. Hold something you brought home. The GM tells you what you remember.

Gathering and haul

Spend an hour at a place to gather one bundle of what's there: Wood, Stone, Fiber, Food or Salvage. A bundle takes a slot. Some things need a tool. Whatever you find out there takes a slot too, and you choose what goes home.

You eat 1 Food a day. A meal cooked at home gives you a **full belly**: your first Warmth roll the next day can't step down.

MADE THING	COSTS	OPENS
Shovel	2 Wood, 1 Stone	Drifts, frozen earth
Hatchet	1 Wood, 2 Stone	Branches, ice, proper firewood
Pick	1 Wood, 2 Salvage	Rock faces
Sled	3 Wood, 1 Fiber	3 extra bundle slots. Can't climb
Lantern	1 Salvage, 1 Fiber. 3 uses, one each Night it's lit. Refill: 1 Fiber	At Night you roll Warmth once an hour
Scarf	2 Fiber	Known
Mittens	2 Fiber	Needs a pattern
Felted boots	3 Fiber	Needs a pattern
Waxed cloak	2 Fiber, 1 Salvage	Needs a pattern

Patterns come from people and from things you find.

ARMS	COSTS	DOES
Spear	2 Wood, 1 Stone	d10, both paws. Against anything that bites, you act first
Bark shield	1 Wood, 1 Fiber	Armour 1, off paw

A web cut down gives 1 **Silk**. Silk counts as Fiber, and some things need it.

A **keepsake** is a found or brought thing you keep to Remember. It takes a slot like anything else.

Conditions

A condition sits in a pack slot until it's cleared.

CONDITION	YOU GET IT	CLEARED BY
Chilled	Warmth would step down from d4	An hour by a fire clears one. A night by a fire clears them all
Hungry	A day without Food	Eating
Exhausted	A night without sleep	A night in a nest
Injured	Hurt badly. Disadvantage on STR and DEX	Three nights at home
Frostbitten	The GM says so. Disadvantage on DEX	Three nights at home

No free pack slot: drop something in the snow to make room. Every pack slot a condition: you go down.